

Morality

Most people living in normal environments develop instinctive senses of right and wrong. Morality seems to be in part hardwired, arising from the conjunction of rationality and emotion.

Where do right and wrong come from?

Social norms based on shared morals exist across all cultures, enabling social cohesion. When making moral decisions, two brain systems come into play: a “rational” system that effortfully and explicitly weighs the pros and cons of possible actions; and a system that rapidly generates emotional, intuitive feelings of right and wrong. Interactions between rationality and emotion are complex, but studying brain activity while people grapple with moral dilemmas has identified the key areas involved.

Moral judgment

When we make decisions, our emotions play a vital role. In order to weigh moral matters, brain areas that are involved in emotional experience coordinate with areas that register facts and consider possible actions and consequences.

KEY



Rational circuit



Emotional circuit

